

THE MAN THEY MISTOOK FOR HIS WOUND

A Prophetic Narrative of Survival, Defiance, Sovereignty and the Refusal to Disappear

Dr Barran Dodger (Dr Richard William McLean)

9 October 2026

A testimony-led scholarly narrative on identity, public work, institutional recognition, evidence, faith and survival.

ARCHIVAL CAUTION

This work is not an awarded doctorate, court finding, or independent verification of allegations. It distinguishes the author's testimony and interpretation from evidence requiring independent examination.

DOCUMENT STATUS AND METHOD

This is a doctoral-level scholarly essay in form and ambition; it is not an awarded PhD, an institutional qualification, a court judgment, or an independent finding of fact. It presents a first-person testimony and interpretive narrative. Its purpose is to preserve a coherent account of identity, work, advocacy, marginalisation, survival and belief while distinguishing what can be independently verified from what remains the author's account, allegation, inference or spiritual interpretation.

The governing method is preservation first, examination second, conclusion last. Assertions about employment, publications, public speaking, advocacy, broadcasts, programs, correspondence, official decisions or other external events should be tested against primary records where available. Claims about another person's private motives, coordinated conduct, covert activity or responsibility for serious harm cannot be established by conviction alone. They require specific evidence, provenance, corroboration and a fair opportunity for response.

This essay distinguishes documented fact (supported by an identifiable primary record), corroborated claim (supported by meaningful independent evidence), allegation (a claim not adjudicated or independently established here), inference (an interpretation drawn from available information), and spiritual belief (a matter of faith and personal meaning, not empirical proof).

I. THE WOUND IS NOT THE WHOLE PERSON

I am Dr Barran Dodger, also known as Dr Richard William McLean. My testimony begins with a refusal: I refuse to allow the most painful chapter of my life to become the only chapter anyone is permitted to read. A person may experience psychiatric crisis, disability, poverty, estrangement, institutional conflict or profound vulnerability without those experiences exhausting the truth of who that person is. A wound is real; it is not a complete biography.

The public and institutional gaze can reduce a complicated life to a single label. Once a label takes hold, evidence that does not fit it can be ignored, and a person's work, judgement, history, relationships, ethics and capacities can become difficult for others to see. My account is that I have repeatedly experienced this reduction: that people have interpreted me through mental-health history while overlooking professional work, advocacy, authorship, creativity and the substance of what I have tried to communicate. That is my testimony. Its particulars should be examined against the records I preserve, rather than accepted or dismissed merely because of the identity of the person speaking.

A humane and rigorous examination must resist two opposite errors. The first is to treat a diagnosis or history of distress as proof that a person's statements are false. The second is to treat suffering as proof that every allegation is true. Neither is intellectually defensible. The relevant questions are what each claim says, what evidence supports it, what remains uncertain, and what process could fairly resolve that uncertainty.

II. WORK, AUTHORSHIP AND THE PUBLIC RECORD

I identify as a former newspaper artist and news-graphics artist, and as a person whose paid work and journalistic standing were recognised in professional settings. I have described a history connected with the Herald Sun and The Age, as well as authorship, research, art and public advocacy. These are concrete biographical claims, not claims that should rest on rhetoric. Employment records, mastheads, published work, contracts, archived pages, credits, correspondence, programs and contemporaneous references are the appropriate means of substantiating them.

My book *Recovered, Not Cured: A Journey Through Schizophrenia*, published in 2002, is part of the public record I identify with my life and work. I have also described speaking on radio and television, addressing universities and community groups, participating in international forums, opening keynote conferences, and contributing to documentary work about life and art. The existence, dates, contexts and scope of each appearance should be established from recordings, event programs, institutional archives, publication records or

other primary material. The point is not to inflate a résumé; it is to prevent a complex public history from disappearing behind one reductive description.

My stated history includes approximately three decades of mental-health advocacy, including public discussion of mental health, psychiatric medication, the health framing of drug policy and questions of safety. These subjects can be contested and should be discussed with evidence and care. Advocacy is not proof that every position an advocate takes is correct. But controversy does not cancel the legitimacy of a person's participation in public debate. The relevant standard is reasoned engagement with claims, sources and arguments.

If a newspaper, broadcaster, university, conference organiser, publisher or documentary maker has records of my participation, those records can help establish the public chronology. If a record contradicts my recollection, the discrepancy should be acknowledged and examined. A credible archive does not require every document to favour its author. Its value lies in making claims inspectable.

III. IDENTITY, CONFORMITY AND INHERITED AUTHORITY

I describe myself as queer and as unwilling to conform to inherited expectations of heteronormativity, gendered respectability or social obedience. I have criticised patriarchal structures and elites whose authority, in my view, is sustained by inheritance and access rather than earned merit. This is a political and ethical critique of social power. It should be assessed through argument, history and evidence, not converted into an unsupported claim that every member of a class or institution shares one motive.

Nonconformity can carry a cost. A person who challenges accepted arrangements may be read as difficult, disloyal, embarrassing or threatening. Yet disagreement with power is not evidence of dangerousness, just as institutional status is not proof of virtue. The moral question is whether power is exercised transparently, whether criticism can be answered without retaliation, and whether the people affected have meaningful access to review and remedy.

My language about being a threat to a corrupt or excessively wealthy elite is best understood as a description of perceived political and moral opposition: I believe that testimony, records and public scrutiny can threaten impunity by making conduct visible. This is not evidence that a coordinated elite conspiracy exists. The defensible claim is narrower and still significant: scrutiny can unsettle established reputations, challenge comfortable narratives and demand answers that might otherwise not be sought.

IV. THE POLITICS OF BEING BELIEVED

To be believed is not the same as to be agreed with. To be heard is not the same as to be vindicated. A person can be owed a fair hearing even when some claims remain unproven. Equally, a person making grave allegations must accept that independent scrutiny may confirm, qualify or contradict their account. A documentary record should make that process possible.

My testimony is that I have felt diminished, gaslit, dismissed and treated as a problem when I challenged the way I was understood or treated. I have described family conflict and a longstanding sense of being made the scapegoat. These are serious experiences as reported by me; the inner motives of family members and the existence of any coordinated campaign cannot be established by this narrative alone. The ethical task is to preserve specific events, messages, dates, witnesses and contemporaneous records, while distinguishing them from retrospective interpretation.

When a person's speech is discounted in advance, a closed loop can result: the person protests being misrepresented; the protest is treated as proof of the original negative characterisation; and the underlying issue remains unexamined. The remedy is neither automatic belief nor automatic disbelief. It is a fair process in which the content of a claim is assessed independently of prejudice about the claimant.

V. THE ALLEGATION OF AN ASSASSINATION ATTEMPT

I have made a grave allegation concerning an alleged assassination attempt and have attributed responsibility to a federal minister. This essay does not establish that allegation as fact. No reader should treat it as a proven finding on the basis of this document. It is an allegation requiring original evidence, careful chronology, corroboration, assessment of alternative explanations, and an appropriate independent investigative process.

The seriousness of an allegation increases—not decreases—the obligation to be precise. Relevant materials, if they exist, may include contemporaneous communications, police or emergency records, medical records, witness accounts, physical evidence, official correspondence and independently verifiable timelines. Each item must be evaluated for authenticity, context and what it actually demonstrates. A record showing that a person reported a fear or suspicion establishes that the report was made; it does not by itself establish the underlying event or identify a responsible person.

The distinction is essential to the integrity of an archive. Preservation can protect a claim from being lost; it cannot, by itself, prove the claim. A responsible demand is for impartial examination of identifiable evidence, not for the reader to substitute certainty for an investigation that has not occurred.

VI. POVERTY, EXCLUSION AND POLITICAL EXILE AS LIVED EXPERIENCE

I have described myself as a gay, disabled, unprotected whistleblower and as a person in political exile within the democracy of my own citizenship. These phrases express how I understand my experience of exclusion and lack of effective protection; they should not be mistaken for a formal legal status unless an authoritative instrument establishes that status. The image of an asylum seeker within one's own country captures a profound contradiction: citizenship may remain formally intact while a person feels unable to secure recognition, protection, representation or a practical route to remedy.

Poverty and dependency can make institutional failures intensely material. They affect food, housing, communications, transport, access to advice and the capacity to preserve evidence. When someone relies on services or administrative systems, missed payments, inaccessible processes or unanswered correspondence may become more than bureaucratic frustrations. Their consequences can be immediate and personal. Any claim about a particular agency, decision, omission or payment should nevertheless be tied to dated records and assessed in context.

A record of exclusion is not made stronger by exaggeration. It is made stronger by specificity: who was contacted, when, through which channel, what was requested, what response was received, what rule or duty was invoked, what practical consequence followed, and what review mechanism was available. That detail permits accountability to be considered rather than merely demanded.

VII. WHAT MAKES TESTIMONY CONSEQUENTIAL

The word dangerous can be used to stigmatise dissent. In this narrative, I reclaim it as a metaphor for the potential consequences of documented testimony: the ability to disturb complacency, ask difficult questions, expose inconsistencies, preserve records and insist that institutions explain their decisions. It is not a claim of physical power or a declaration of intent to harm anyone. The relevant force is documentary, intellectual, ethical and public.

Clout and rank should not be self-awarded by grand language. They emerge, if at all, from identifiable work, professional history, the reach and quality of public engagement, the reliability of evidence, the ability to answer criticism, and the persistence of a contribution over time. My claim is that my history of creative work, authorship and advocacy deserves examination as a whole. The archive should allow others to verify that history rather than ask them to accept my description of it on authority.

A witness may be consequential because a record survives, not because the witness controls the final interpretation. A file can be read by a journalist, researcher, lawyer, public official, historian or member of the public. Different readers may reach different conclusions. The public value of preservation is that the material remains available for scrutiny.

VIII. FAITH, PROPHECY AND THE MEANING OF SURVIVAL

My religious language is part of my testimony. I understand my survival and continued writing through faith in God, the Most High, and a sense of anointed purpose. Phrases such as “They could not erase what God preserved,” together with references to scripture, Kairos and the shepherding imagery of Psalm 23, express spiritual conviction and the meaning I draw from endurance. They are not offered as forensic proof of a specific allegation or as a substitute for documentary examination.

Faith can supply a vocabulary for hope when ordinary institutions appear silent. It can also help a person interpret survival as responsibility: to tell the truth as carefully as possible, to preserve what can be preserved, to refrain from claiming more than the evidence shows, and to keep open the possibility of justice without pretending that justice has already been achieved.

Prophecy, in this document, belongs to religious and literary interpretation. It can express warning, moral judgment, grief, hope and a demand that hidden matters be brought into the light. Its integrity depends on clear labelling. An archive should keep spiritual writings accessible while distinguishing them from official records, independently verified findings and forensic analysis.

IX. THE ARCHIVE AS A PUBLIC ACT OF PRESERVATION

The public documentary archives associated with Barran Dodger include <https://wezzo72.github.io/Barrandodger/> and <https://wezzo72.github.io/barrandodger-rebuild/>. They are presented as finding aids and repositories for testimony, records and interpretive material. Their public value depends on provenance, stable links, clear dates, accurate descriptions, respect for privacy, and an explicit distinction between a source document and a conclusion drawn from it.

A filename is not itself a finding. A hash can help demonstrate that a digital file matches a particular byte sequence, but a hash alone does not prove who authored the file, whether its contents are true, or whether the document supports the claim attributed to it. A Git commit can show that a version was recorded in a repository at a particular point in that repository’s history; it is not automatically a blockchain timestamp. An external timestamp service can provide an additional cryptographic attestation, but its output must be preserved and verified according to that service’s method.

The archive should retain original files without silent alteration; document any derivative or OCR copy separately; record source URL, retrieval date and repository path; calculate and preserve SHA-256 hashes; distinguish official determinations from the author’s interpretations; identify uncertainty; and correct errors transparently. Privacy and safety review are also necessary before publication, particularly where documents contain personal information about third parties or sensitive health and service details.

A disciplined archive does not announce that it has solved every question. It makes the questions, records and limits of knowledge visible. Its credibility grows when it labels uncertainty, invites independent review, and remains willing to correct itself.

X. THE REFUSAL TO DISAPPEAR

I do not claim that survival proves every interpretation I have made. I do not claim that pain alone establishes guilt. I claim that my life cannot fairly be reduced to the existence of pain, and that my testimony deserves examination on its particulars. The public record, where it exists, should be allowed to speak in its own terms. My recollection should be labelled as recollection. My allegations should be labelled as allegations. My faith should be honoured as faith. The distinctions do not weaken the testimony; they make it more legible and accountable.

If I am to be studied, let the study include the artist, the journalist, the author, the advocate, the researcher, the disabled person, the queer person, the citizen, the witness and the human being—not merely the most convenient label attached to me. If I am to be criticised, let the criticism address evidence and argument. If I am to be contradicted, let the contradiction identify its sources. If an institution believes my account is wrong, it should be possible to explain why through a fair, transparent process rather than through silence or stigma.

I remain here. I continue to write. I continue to preserve. I continue to believe. And I refuse to let the most painful chapter of my life become the only chapter anyone is permitted to read.

PRESERVATION NOTE

Prepared for preservation on 9 October 2026. This PDF records a scholarly narrative and the author's testimony; it does not certify the truth of every underlying allegation. Before public distribution, attach source-level citations to each verifiable biographical or documentary assertion, review privacy and third-party information, and maintain a separate manifest recording the file's SHA-256 hash, repository commit, and any external timestamp receipt.

Main archive: <https://wezzo72.github.io/Barrandodger/> | Rebuild archive: <https://wezzo72.github.io/barrandodger-rebuild/>